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Philip the evangelist

The table-server who carried the gospel to Samaria, to an African official, and down the coast.

Philip was one of the seven chosen to care for the widows in the Jerusalem church. When persecution broke out after Stephen's death, he went to Samaria, a place most Jews avoided, and preached Christ with great results. Then an angel sent him to a desert road, where he met an Ethiopian official reading Isaiah. Philip pointed him to Jesus and baptized him, then preached town to town up to Caesarea. Twenty years later he was still there, "Philip the evangelist," with four daughters who prophesied.

At a glance

Name	Greek <i>Philippos</i> , "lover of horses"
Family	Four daughters "which did prophesy" (Acts 21:9)
Role	One of the seven; "the evangelist" (Acts 6:5; 21:8)
When	Active c. AD 30s–50s
Key places	Jerusalem; Samaria; the Gaza road; Caesarea
Key people	Stephen; Simon the sorcerer; the Ethiopian; Paul
Main passages	Acts 6:1–6; 8:4–40; 21:8–9
Not the same as	Philip, one of the twelve apostles (John 1:43–46)

"Then Philip opened his mouth, and began at the same scripture, and preached unto him Jesus."

Acts 8:35, KJV

The life of Philip the evangelist

Dates are approximate (AD). Acts gives no years. The mission to Samaria follows Stephen's death, c. AD 33–35, and Paul's visit to Caesarea is c. AD 57.

Early church Jerusalem	● Chosen as one of the seven When Greek-speaking widows are neglected, the church chooses seven men full of the Spirit and wisdom. Philip is named second, after Stephen. The apostles pray and lay hands on them. <i>Acts 6:1–6</i>
c. AD 33–35 Samaria	● Preaches Christ Persecution scatters the believers. Philip goes down to the city of Samaria and preaches Christ. Crowds listen, unclean spirits are cast out, the lame are healed, and "there was great joy in that city." <i>Acts 8:1–8</i>
Samaria	● Baptizes many, including Simon Men and women believe and are baptized. Even Simon, a well-known sorcerer, believes and follows Philip. Peter and John come from Jerusalem, and the Samaritans receive the Holy Ghost. <i>Acts 8:9–17</i>
The Gaza road	● Meets the Ethiopian An angel sends Philip south to a desert road. He finds a treasurer of the queen of Ethiopia reading Isaiah, explains the passage, preaches Jesus, and baptizes him in roadside water. <i>Acts 8:26–38</i>
Azotus to Caesarea	● Preaches along the coast The Spirit catches Philip away. He is found at Azotus and preaches in all the cities along the way until he comes to Caesarea. <i>Acts 8:39–40</i>
c. AD 57 Caesarea	● Hosts Paul At the end of his third journey, Paul and his companions stay many days in Philip's house. The prophet Agabus comes and warns Paul about what awaits him in Jerusalem. <i>Acts 21:8–14</i>

Key activities

The KJV includes Acts 8:37, the Ethiopian's confession of faith. Many of the oldest Greek manuscripts do not have this verse, so some modern translations put it in a footnote.

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- 1 Served the widows.** He was trusted to oversee the daily care of the church's needy widows. *Acts 6:3-5*

 - 2 Crossed a cultural line.** He took the gospel to Samaria, and "there was great joy in that city." *Acts 8:5-8*

 - 3 Did signs.** Unclean spirits came out, and many who were palsied and lame were healed. *Acts 8:6-7, 13*

 - 4 Obeyed without delay.** Told to go to a desert road, "he arose and went." *Acts 8:26-27*

 - 5 Ran to the chariot.** The Spirit said, "Go near, and join thyself to this chariot," and Philip ran to it. *Acts 8:29-30*

 - 6 Explained Scripture.** He asked, "Understandest thou what thou readest?" and preached Jesus from Isaiah 53. *Acts 8:30-35*

 - 7 Baptized the Ethiopian.** The official went on his way rejoicing. *Acts 8:36-39*

 - 8 Kept preaching.** He preached in every city from Azotus to Caesarea, and years later was still known as the evangelist. *Acts 8:40; 21:8*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Philip.

Old Testament

Isaiah 53:7–8	The passage the Ethiopian was reading (Acts 8:32–35)
Echo: Isaiah 56:3–5	Faithful eunuchs promised a better name
Echo: Psalm 68:31	"Ethiopia shall soon stretch out her hands unto God"

New Testament

Acts 6:5	Listed second among the seven
Acts 8:4–40	Samaria and the Ethiopian
Acts 21:8–9	"Philip the evangelist," with four prophesying daughters
Echo: Acts 1:8	Judaea, Samaria, the uttermost part: Philip reaches each
Tradition	Often confused with Philip the apostle; later life in Asia Minor uncertain

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Philip do after the angel and the Spirit spoke to him (Acts 8:26–30)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Philip began with the very passage the Ethiopian was reading?
3. *Apply:* Who might welcome a gentle question about faith from you this week?
4. *Apply:* What small job could you take on this month to serve your church or neighbours?